

felicitated for his elevation to Indian cricket's top administrative post.

Vivek Krishnan

Whispers beneath the afternoon sun

"But where's the story in that?" Diary, still wet behind the ears in 2021, had asked a veteran journalist.

The old hand had smiled. "Every subject has a story. You just have to listen long enough."

The line resurfaced years later on a hot afternoon in Surat.

Bengal and Railways were grinding through their afternoon nets at the Lalbhai Contractor Stadium. Amid the metronomic thud of leather on turf, Diary noticed a man, perhaps in his fifties, quietly observing the session from behind a fence.

A wrinkled shirt clung to his wiry frame. His trousers had clearly seen better days. Thick glasses magnified the fatigue around his eyes, yet his gaze never shifted from the boy charging in at Railways skipper Pratham Singh.

"Fan?" Diary ventured, more instinct than question.

"Coach," came the quiet reply.

When the bowler walked back to his mark, the resemblance was too striking to ignore. "You must be the father," Diary guessed.

"Not on the cricket field," the man said without hesitation.

The speedster's action offered clues about who he took after. His load-up carried a hint of Brett Lee, the release had shades of Dale Steyn. The pace felt around 120 clicks to the naked eye, but it was the intent and repeatability that drew attention.

He had piqued visiting coach Laxmi Ratan Shukla's interest too. After a long chat, Shukla asked him to bowl at Vishal Bhati. The batter was beaten comprehensively first ball.

Eventually, the father shared the boy's name, though not for print. "Not yet. I will share my number. But we will



Quiet watcher: Behind the rusted mesh, a quiet observer follows every ball as if it carries a future he already believes in. **Santadeep Dey**

tell our story only when he has played for India. At least India A," he said.

He returned to watching his son bowl.

Diary, who stayed rooted, caught between admiration and surprise, had met plenty of young cricketers and plenty more parents before who chase attention. But this man was different. He guarded his son's story like treasured china, brought out only for the right occasion.

Everyone has a story to tell. Some simply wait for the moment the world finally sees what they already do.

Santadeep Dey

Reset mode

Rohit Sharma tuned up for the ODI series against South Africa with a training session at the MCA-BKC ground.

Arriving for light work, Rohit exchanged quick chats with Mumbai cricketers bowling in the nets and met



Getting back into the groove: Rohit Sharma returns to training in Mumbai with a light session at BKC. **Shayan Acharya**

Dhaval Kulkarni and Atul Ranade. While cameras and fans gathered, he spent around 30 minutes doing sprints and fitness drills. He did not bat.

Rohit recently played the ODI series against Australia and scored a century in the final game. Having retired from Tests and T20Is, he now features only in ODIs. As he aims to continue until the 2027 World Cup, it remains to be seen whether he makes himself available for Mumbai in the Vijay Hazare Trophy.

His last appearance for Mumbai came in a Ranji Trophy match against Jammu and Kashmir last year. Earlier this year, he guided India to a Champions Trophy win, before announcing his retirement from Test cricket in May.

Speculation continues over whether Rohit and Virat Kohli fit into the plans for 2027, but selection committee chairman Ajit Agarkar has stated that it would be unfair to subject the duo to constant scrutiny.

Shayan Acharya